



I HAVE NEWLY DEvised 28 LETTERS

KING SEJONG INTRODUCES A NEW SCRIPT (1443)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Chosŏn Korea

BEFORE

918 The Goryeo dynasty is founded.

1270 Goryeo comes under the structural, military, and administrative influence of the Mongol Yuan dynasty.

1392 Yi Sŏnggye founds the Chosŏn dynasty.

1420 King Sejong founds the Chiphyŏn-jŏn research institution.

AFTER

1445 A 365-volume medical encyclopedia is published.

1447 The first work printed in Han'gŭl is published.

1542 The first sŏwŏn private academy opens. The academies become centers of debate and house neo-Confucian texts.

1910 Japan annexes Korea and deposes the last Chosŏn ruler.

encouraged by Korea's king that were designed to stabilize Korea and improve prosperity, and enabled his Chosŏn (or Yi) dynasty to survive for another 450 years.

Rise of the Yi dynasty

The Mongol Yuan dynasty had interfered in the Korean Peninsula from the late 12th century until 1368, when it was overthrown by the Ming dynasty. Korea was left in chaos as its Koryŏ kings tried to reverse the effects of a century's authoritarian domination. The redistribution of land and the sacking of pro-Mongol ministers led almost to civil war, but in 1392 Sejong's grandfather Yi Sŏnggye, a former general, stepped in, deposed the last Koryŏ king, and assumed the throne as King Taejo.

King Taejo's immediate priority was to secure stability, and the installation of a state ideology based on neo-Confucianism was key to achieving that. This ideology sought to reestablish proper relations between the ruler and his people, and conferred privileged status on a bureaucratic class that would act as guardian of the social hierarchy. Buddhism had been the dominant ideology under the Koryŏ dynasty, but Taejo undermined its hold in the region by breaking up large estates controlled by Buddhist temples and redistributing the land, some to Confucian shrines.

Neo-Confucianism emphasized the importance of education as a way of producing a class of literati capable of ensuring the harmonious running of the state. Taejo's grandson, King Sejong (reigned 1418–1450) raised this principle

In 1443, the Korean court of King Sejong announced the creation of Han'gŭl, a national alphabet for the Korean language, and launched a program of publications in the new script. The measure was one of a number of strategies